

river enters the city, and another body at the back of the place where it issues forth, with orders to march into the town by the bed of the stream, as soon as the water became shallow enough: he then himself drew off with the unwarlike portion of his host, and made for the place where Nitocris dug the basin for the river, where he did exactly what she had done formerly: he turned the Euphrates by a canal into the basin,<sup>1</sup> which was then a marsh, on which the river sank to such an extent that the natural bed of the stream became fordable. Hereupon the Persians who had been left for the purpose at Babylon by the river-side, entered the stream, which had now sunk so as to reach about midway up a man's thigh, and thus got into the town. Had the Babylonians been apprised of what Cyrus was about, or had they noticed their danger, they would not have allowed the entrance of the Persians within the city, which was what ruined them utterly, but would have made fast all the street-gates which gave upon the river, and mounting upon the walls along both sides of the stream, would so have caught the enemy as it were in a trap. But, as it was, the Persians came upon them by surprise and so took the city. Owing to the vast size of the place, the inhabitants of the central parts (as the residents at Babylon declare) long after the outer portions of the town were taken, knew nothing of what had chanced, but as they were engaged in a festival, continued dancing and revelling until they learnt the capture but too certainly. Such, then, were the circumstances of the first taking of Babylon.<sup>2</sup>

192. Among many proofs which I shall bring forward of the power and resources of the Babylonians, the following is of special account. The whole country under the dominion of the Persians, besides paying a fixed tribute, is parcelled out into divisions, which have to supply food to the Great King and his army during different portions of the year.<sup>3</sup> Now out of the twelve months which go to a year, the district of Babylon fur-

<sup>1</sup> Mr. Grote says that Cyrus "caused *another* reservoir and *another* canal of communication to be dug, by means of which he drew off the water of the Euphrates" (vol. iv. p. 285). But Herodotus says that he turned the river into the *same* reservoir—ἐς τὴν λίμνην—which was at the time a marsh—ἐοῦσαν ἑλος. And indeed, had he done otherwise, he would have expended time and labour very unnecessarily.

<sup>2</sup> Herodotus intends to contrast this *first* capture with the *second* capture by Darius Hystaspes, of which he speaks in the latter portion of the third Book. We learn, however, by the mode of speech used, that he was not aware of any former occasion on which the city of Babylon had been taken by an enemy.

<sup>3</sup> See the Essay appended to Book iii., "On the Persian System of Administration and Government."